3 Short Short Stories

A bit out of the ordinary

Ursula West

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Preface

Hi there!

These three stories were previously published in 'Tune In' which is a popular glossy magazine in Malta.

They are quick and easy to read and I enjoyed writing them.

Enjoy reading them.

Ursula West

Story 1

20 Million

Everybody has a wish

20 million! 20 million, what I could do with 20 million euros!

Sophie twiddled her pen and looked at the blank piece of paper.

"You can write anything, you can write anything you want," said the voice in her ear.

"Shut up!" she snapped.

"A car, yes, that's first." She wrote 'Red Ferrari,' crossed it out 'Lamborghini.'"

She sighed. "What else?"

"A holiday in the Caribbean." She crossed out 'holiday' and wrote, 'beach-house'.

That was as far as she got before slamming the pen flat onto the table.

"No! This is STUPID!"

She whirled around and glared into the air behind her.

"You don't exist! And I have NOT won 20 million!"

She turned again and slumped onto the kitchen chair, burying her head in her hands.

She sighed.

There were two kinds of things that annoyed her.

1. People who didn't phone.

2. Not knowing if she wanted them to phone.

She took hold of the pen and scribbled, 'He phones and we are mad, mad, mad in love.'

Point '2' had answered itself. She closed the notebook and stroked the cover, slowly pushing it away. She felt guilty somehow putting that on a wish list. She shouldn't have said it out loud. Writing it down was even worse.

It was all the coke can's fault.

She picked it up from the table and went to the window, turning it in the light to see the words under the dirty surface.

What would happen if she rubbed it again? Would he go back into the can or would another one come out?

"No, twice to that question," said the voice. "It's my can and no, I'm not going in there again. Well, not now."

"Well, it's MY life!" said Sophie. "There should only be one in that as well."

"Really? That's not what you wrote a minute ago. So you want him to phone you do you? What will you do when he does? Will you put him back in a can when you're fed up?"

She tutted loudly. "As if you would understand; you're a smoky, spirity thingy."

"Smoky, spirity things have feelings too, you know."

There was silence. That's it. She had officially gone mad. She rubbed the dirt off the can anyway and put it back on the table. It wasn't like the beach. Nothing happened, no smoke poured out, no second misty shape.

Sophie's mind scanned the past two weeks. Pictures of the chance meeting in the café, the walks, being out with him and his friends. Funny how they could shut everything and everyone else out and be alone together, even in a crowd. Why did she have to ruin it? It was true, she really was busy those times. Too busy, it seems. He never phoned back and somehow, she couldn't bring herself to phone him, either. What was wrong with her?

It had been a good, quiet walk on the beach until she had picked up that old can. Everything changed after that. This thing had just invaded her space, got into her life with just one rub of an old dirty can and now it was interfering with everything she was.

She looked up. "So, you're my Genii then? You're going to give me 20 million euro and a wish list."

"Yes."

"Just like that!"

"Yes, but one word of caution."

"Here it comes. I knew it. There's always a catch."

"When he calls, you will need to move over and make room in your one life. You are inviting him in or you aren't. You must understand this first. Otherwise, forget it. It's a waste of time!"

"That's it?"

"That's it."

"What about the other stuff?"

"What stuff?"

"House, car, all that? What's the other catch?"

"Just stuff. 20 million, do what you want with it. I'm not interested."

There was a distant ringing noise. It sounded faintly familiar.

"Bye then", said the smoke. The ringing got louder.

"Bye", whispered Sophie. Everything went dark.

The doorbell was ringing as she sat up and looked around her tiny, dark room. She didn't even have a kitchen table, never mind a coke-can genii. She dragged herself awake with a coffee and shower and smiled at the memory. Her notepad lay blank and empty on the worktop. Ignoring the doorbell, she grabbed hold of her pen and started scribbling.

'Car, beach-house, Pucci swimwear,' she wrote and paused. 'Phone call', she continued, then sighed and shuffled off to answer the doorbell.

Two men in official looking uniforms stood there holding a large envelope. "Can you sign for this?" said the man as he held it out towards her. He smiled warmly. "Congratulations," he said, "spend it well." She glanced behind them, looking left, then right in rapid succession.

"Is this a joke? It's not a cheque for 20 million, by any chance?" She laughed, but they did not laugh back. Instead, they both smiled rather strangely. "You are the 20th winner of the 'Random Gift' prize from Philanthropy Anonymous." The tall one pushed the envelope into her hand and then, in perfect unison, they took a step backwards and made a quick bow. Together, they lifted their caps, turned briskly, and walked away.

She closed the door, still staring at the purple envelope, gradually noticing the ringing in the background.

Turning around like a half awake zombi, she stared at her phone on the worktop. It continued to ring while its

vibration was moving it nearer to the edge. But the only thing she noticed, as she inched forwards to pick it up, was HIS name, emblazoned across its glossy face. There is no way I could describe the expression on her face. No way, no way at all.

Story 2

New Neighbours

Mouse-eye view

They reckoned that Mica Beha's family numbered around 200 in all. That was, if you could count them. Mice are hardly ever still, so the count would always have to be a good guess.

Things had become difficult for him, though. It was the human problem again.

The Ox quarter was a great place for finding seeds. Every day, they would scurry over there and search right under their noses. They loomed like gigantic towering buildings above them, but when the big beasts saw Mica or his brothers, they never put a foot out of place. The humans! Huh.! They would try to stamp on them on purpose. Yes indeed, it looked as though it was actually on purpose!

This was why Mica was worried. The whole place was filling up more and more each day. Donkeys, oxen, mules all being stabled in this one place. Of course, it was big enough, but it was the owners of the beasts that were the problem. Tramping in and out with no warning.

"Mica!"

He turned. Lumi was tugging at his tail, shouting in a hoarse whispering squeak.

"What?" he whispered back.

"I think I'm going to start soon."

Mica looked at her round, fat tummy. So beautiful, so pregnant. His sweet Lumi!

"O.K.," he said. "There's something happening though. I don't like the look of it. Something strange."

"What?" croaked Lumi.

A large foot shot past both of them and a wooden plank dropped from nowhere and landed just in front of their doorway, blocking all chance of an escape.

"That!" shouted Mica and yanked Lumi into the next stall. The donkey occupant blinked at them.

"Mica, Mica! What will we do!" He didn't answer, but gently led her over to a pile of straw and discarded feathers in the stall's corner. He smiled.

"What we always do," he said. "Just get on with what we have to do. No matter what." He nuzzled her tiny nose and gathered some loose fluff around her. Lumi smiled back and settled down in the corner.

Mica went back to watch.

A woman and a man were being shown into the now empty stall. A big human, the Innkeeper who owned the stable, was hauling something behind him. He looked uncomfortable. "It's all I have. You should have thought about this before." He looked at the other man who was supporting the woman in his arms. "Well, I suppose it's difficult," he muttered.

He dropped the large object on the floor, a long cloth bag, filled with straw

"I'll be back with some food and water later," the Innkeeper said.

"He's leaving them there!" whispered Mica.

The Innkeeper mumbled something else, then shuffled out.

"I want to see," said Lumi and lay on her side, peering under the stall.

Mica scurried over to her and scratched at a loose piece of wood, revealing a good sized crack, just big enough for them both to see through.

The woman was quite young, the man older, and he stroked her head, just as Mica had done to Lumi.

The woman smiled up at him, almost as if she were comforting him.

"Soon, my dear. Soon." She whispered.

He sat down beside her and wrapped his arms around her.

Mica moved closer to hold Lumi, and they both watched them together.

There was silence; such a silence!

A rustle here, a sound of breathing there, then music. Music from somewhere; who knows where? Like distant harmonies.

Then a baby's cry.

The woman bent over and lifted her newborn to her breasts.

The man covered them both.

Mica turned to Lumi and pointed to the straw beside them.

"Look," he said. "I told you, you would do it." He turned around and gathered their new offspring together.

"Bethlehem has eight new mice," he said
"And one new human," said Lumi, still smiling.
"Yes," said Mica.
"Hope it's a good one!"

Story 3

The Wedding Plan

Young Love

Location: Tuscany

Occasion: The marriage of Leopold and Matilda

Time: The day before the wedding

Situation: Catastrophe!

Leo was desperate. He drove on through the mist, twisting the map in his free hand. It's all Tilly's fault, he thought. "Let's get married in Tuscany!" he mimicked and winced as he drove on.

At least HIS idea had some sense. He had arranged for them to have a day to themselves before the wedding. A sort of role-play adventure, a game. It seemed like a simple, good idea, but his soon to be bride, Tilly, had a bad feeling about it.

"You want us to meet by chance? WHERE!"

"In an Italian country inn." He handed her the map.

She looked down at it and then up at him. "How did you find this place?"

"Friends of mine stumbled on it a few years ago. They gave me their maps. It's all marked." He bent over and followed the red line with his finger, then smiled encouragingly. Tilly, despite her misgivings, agreed to do it.

* * *

The rain had stopped now, but Leo was frowning. Tilly's worried look, as she took off in the taxi, had upset him. "It's going to work when we get to the inn," he told himself.

Removing one clenched fist from the steering wheel, he checked the map again. Was this the place? He peered through the misty windscreen, and his heart sank.

"Oh Tilly," he sighed. "Look at you!"

It looked like her taxi had arrived way too soon. Now her bedraggled figure, ankle deep in mud, stood alone beside an old barn. He pulled up and leapt out, running towards her over the gravel.

A hot tear escaped from the corner of her eye, and she brushed it away with contempt. Trying to gather her dignity was like clutching the wind, so she stiffened her back instead and turned away.

Leo mumbled an apology. "Bill phoned and," he paused, "this place is, well, not that easy to find. Is it? Where's the Inn?"

Tilly spun around, ready to snap back a fitting answer, when a loud chugging noise stopped her short. A tractor was coming towards them.

"Maybe someone blew it up!" she hissed.

A man was waving at them. "Buongiorno!" he called.

Tilly pulled at Leo's sleeve.

"Quick, let's get to your car."

It was too late. The old farmer got off the tractor and was coming towards them.

"Come stai? You come to see the farm? No?

"No," said Leo, not sure whether that actually meant 'yes'. "Sorry, we are just looking for an inn, Taverna."

"My son tell me you come."

"It must be someone else," snapped Tilly. She didn't even try to mask her Medusa look of anger. "We are getting married tomorrow in the city." She turned to look at Leo. "My boyfriend just wanted to show me the countryside," she quipped.

Leo's jaw stiffened. He sighed and said nothing.

The man looked from one to the other.

"No matter, you come now. I show you this lovely farm."

He had turned and was walking off towards the nearest building.

They followed him, too tired to argue.

Entering the barn, they stopped short. The farmer was swinging a rope over a high rafter.

"I tell you big secret about married. Big, big secret. Come, you hold this. I tell you how to make good married." He walked over to Leo and put one end of the long rope into his hand. "Come, madam, you take other side."

They stood, each holding one end.

"Now you pull. Go now, pull. Pull hard. Both."

They pulled.

"Tell me now," said the farmer. "What happened?"

"Nothing!"

He smiled and nodded. "Remember that," he whis-

pered. "When you pull against each other, you don't get nowhere!"

He turned and walked off, laughing and smiling to himself.

"Taverna is round corner," he called

They let go of the rope and collapsed into the soft hay behind them

It wasn't clear who laughed first, but they couldn't stop.

"Who says we skip the inn?"

Situation: Back on Track.